

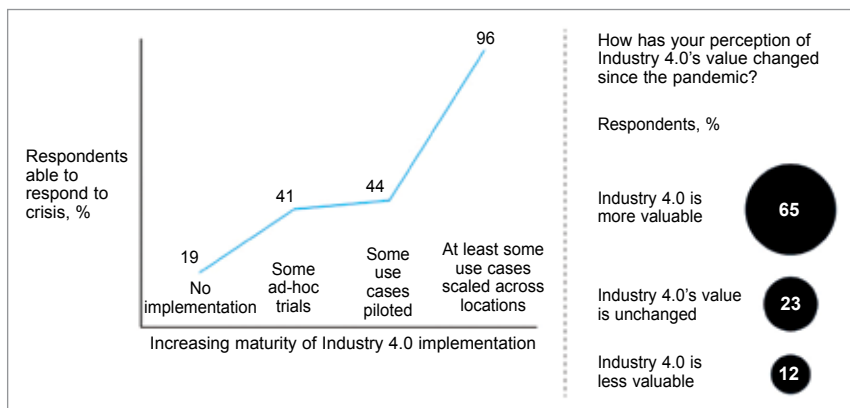


Fig. 1: Companies whose Industry 4.0 implementation is more mature report stronger ability to respond to crisis (Source: McKinsey & Company)

pre-pandemic era, there will also be a post-pandemic era. The use of technology to define the process and yield results for yourself and for your clients will only increase in the post-pandemic era. This is the right time to start working on having a digital strategy in place.”

What is digital strategy?

The word strategy, as defined by different dictionaries, stands for a plan that one prepares to achieve something. Business strategy, however, has different definitions available in books and on the web. But the goal always remains the same, and that is to achieve and maintain leadership in one's vertical of business today, tomorrow, and day after.

“Most of the people contemplate digital strategy by deploying some software like AI, ML, or IoT. That's where I think most of the digital strategies fail because their provenance is not rooted in the right mindset,” explains Anand Tamboli of Anand Tamboli & Company, who was keynote speaker at recent India Electronics Week and is author of a book on Artificial Intelligence.

He adds, “The environment is changing every single day. In order to execute your ideas and plans, you have to continuously adapt. That is where digital strategy or a plan to adapt to those changes comes into place. Digital strategy is the pivotal requirement to gain leadership and to maintain that leadership.”

Many companies had to shut operations during the coronavirus-induced lockdowns and wait for the lockdowns

to be lifted to start functioning again. It was a matter of survival for such companies. Paying their vendors and employees, and meet project deadlines at the same time, were some of the challenges they faced every day. Most of these companies had no digital strategy in place.

But there were also many companies that not only managed to survive but also came out as winners in their respective verticals. Most of these had deployed use-cases around leveraging IoT way before the lockdowns were announced, or immediately before the same.

Lakshmanan says, “Digital transformation comes as a very important journey, both for the leaders and the organisations. I have seen examples of companies that, before lockdowns, had big plans for the digital transformation journey, but they had to change plans because of the situations arising due to coronavirus lockdowns.”

A report by KPMG has termed Covid 19 as the perfect storm for digital acceleration. This report notes that the Covid-19 pandemic has exposed a clear digital divide. **Those companies which had already invested in digital operating models/enablers have fared much better than those which had not.** In fact, for many businesses, the continuity of operations critically depends on their digital capabilities.

No wonder, searches for the terms around the word ‘contactless’ have seen a jump of more than seven times on different search engines. Deloitte rates this increase as a dramatic uptick in the use of digital technologies that help reduce face-to-face interactions and safeguard customer and employee health and well-being.

Overcoming the challenges

A plethora of challenges fell upon the electronics industry when coronavirus started spreading like wildfire. The biggest of these challenges came in the form of supply-chain disruptions. Some of these challenges continue to haunt the industry even today. Logistic companies had to close operations on account of lockdowns and only the essential commodities were allowed to be transported from one place to another. As a lot of companies were relying on Chinese companies for supply of critical components used in electronics manufacturing, these challenges became a nightmare as all international flights to and from China were put on hold.

“The massive challenges for our industry have been very common. For IoT, you have to have the hardware

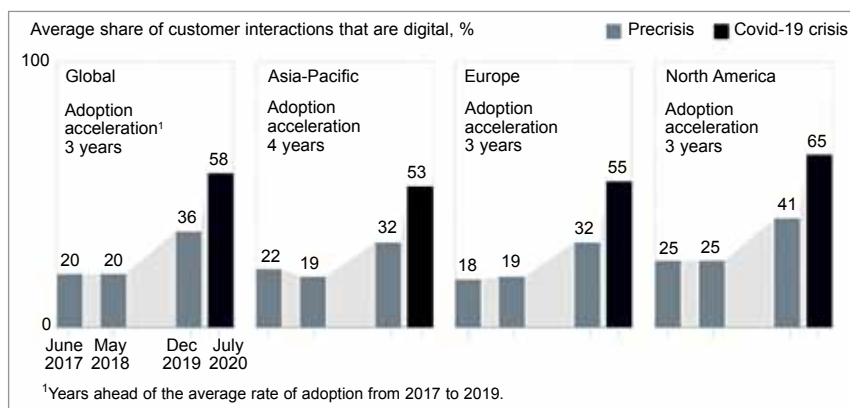


Fig. 2: The Covid-19 crisis has accelerated the digitisation of customer interactions by several years (Source: McKinsey & Company)